the newspaper stating that the reports would ‘do nothing other than to “create” tensions that in fact do not exist’. He added: ‘What should be recognised and highly commended is the magnanimity of Mr Mody himself in announcing these modifications on his becoming aware of the controversy and placing the interest of harmony at Tata Steel above all else. Russi Mody deserves to be congratulated by everyone rather than be criticised.’

But Mody did not take kindly to the fact that he was made to withdraw the redesignation orders.

The battleground soon shifted from Bombay House to Jamshedpur. It was now an open confrontation between Mody and Irani. Neither lost an opportunity to attack the other. The most revealing incident happened in February 1992, when Irani announced the possibility of TISCO raising steel prices after the Union Budget. Mody responded by sending an acerbic letter to Irani: ‘Your views on steel prices … is a subject with which you are not only unfamiliar but it is not within your jurisdiction. As a Joint Managing Director you are very keen to establish the fact that you control the whole Company and all its activities. The sooner you realise that it is not so, it would be better for you.’

He followed it up with a letter to the editor of PTI, saying that steel pricing did not fall under Irani’s purview as he was not in charge of commercial activities.

The company affairs had now become a public spectacle. On Ratan’s request, JRD intervened and Mody yielded. He wrote to JRD stating that they had ‘decided to put a big “X” against all that has happened in the last 3 months’. Mody and Irani put out a press release clarifying that they had worked through their differences concerning the company administration.

Mody’s Pushback

The adoption of the retirement policy was a double whammy for Mody. He was already seventy-four, in breach of the retirement age prescribed for an MD. He was also less than a year away from reaching the age limit for a non-executive chairman.

Mody had not attended the meeting in which the retirement policy was discussed. Ratan, however, wrote to him on 9 April 1992, informing him about the board’s unanimous adoption of the policy. Through the letter, he also sought Mody’s ‘full support’ for it. But Mody was not willing to step